

Women Authoritative Teaching Restricted

prc-women-authoritative-teaching-restricted

Worship Structure · Order in Assembly · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported from a narrow set of texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Depends on a contested manuscript reading

Statement under examination

Women are not to exercise authoritative teaching ministry over mixed adult assemblies (sermon preaching, doctrinal teaching of mixed adults, leading the assembly authoritatively).

In plain language

The question asks whether the Bible restricts authoritative public teaching of mixed adult gatherings, such as preaching the sermon or teaching doctrine to a mixed audience, to men. The Greek words in the cited verses point in two directions, and that is the heart of the dispute. Some verses sound restrictive. First Timothy 2:12 says "I do not permit a woman to teach" (didaskein) "or to authentein" (authenteo) "over a man". A direct check of the text confirms the verb "to authentein" (authenteo) appears only here in the whole New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so there is no other passage to fix whether it means "to hold ordinary authority" or "to domineer", and the two verbs joined by the word "nor" (oude) may name two separate things or one combined idea of domineering teaching. First Corinthians 14:34 says the women should "keep silent" (sigao) in the assemblies and not speak, but the check shows the same silence word is used twice earlier in that very chapter, once for a tongue-speaker with no interpreter and once for a prophet who should yield, each in an "if" clause aimed at a specific situation, which raises the question whether the women command is absolute or aimed at a particular disorder. First Timothy 2:13 grounds the directive by noting Adam was formed first, an appeal to the creation order, though whether that makes the rule permanent or fits a local setting is not settled by the words. Other verses point the opposite way. First Corinthians 11:5 plainly assumes a woman may pray or "prophesy" (propheteuo) aloud in the gathering and only regulates how, and the same prophesying word describes Philip's four daughters in Acts 21:9. Acts 18:26 shows Priscilla, named before her husband in the copies checked, helping to "expound" (ektitheimi) the way of God to Apollos, a man, using a strong word for doctrinal exposition, though in a private setting. Titus 2:3 commands older women to be "teachers of good" (kalodidaskalos), a word built on the teach root, but aimed at the younger women. The trouble is that the words themselves do not settle the matter. A single rare verb that occurs only once, a silence command that may be situational, a learning-in-quietness phrase that may describe demeanor rather than full muteness, and clear cases of women praying, prophesying, and instructing all leave room for more than one careful reading. Because the same vocabulary supports both a restrictive and a more open conclusion, and because the silence text carries a known manuscript question about where it belongs that the available data cannot settle, the lexical pattern here is genuinely contested rather than decisive.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0076	Ἀδάμ	Adam	Adam	9
G0177	ἀκατακάλυπτος	akatakalyptos	uncovered	2
G0207	Ἀκύλας	Akylas	Aquila	6

G0435	άνήρ	anēr	man	
G0538	ἀπατάω	apatao	to trick	3
G0831	αὐθεντέω	authenteo	to domineer	1
G1135	γυνή	gunē	woman	
G1320	διδάσκαλος	didaskalos	teacher	
G1321	διδάσκω	didasko	to teach	97
G1620	ἐκτίθημι	ektitheimi	to explain/expose	4
G1818	ἐξαπατάω	exapatao	to deceive	6
G2010	ἐπιτρέπω	epitrepo	to permit	18
G2271	ἡσυχία	hesychia	quietness	4
G2567	καλοδιδάσκαλος	kalodidaskalos	teaching good	1
G2776	κεφαλή	kephale	head	75
G2980	λαλέω	laleo	to speak	297
G3129	μανθάνω	manthano	to learn	25
G4395	προφητεύω	propheteuo	to prophesy	28
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	
G4601	σιγάω	sigao	be silent	9
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotasso	to subject	38

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: False · Pan-canonical: False

This practice proposition turns on the same contested wording as the parallel office question, but applied to the activity of authoritative teaching of mixed adults rather than to a named office. A direct query of the lexical store confirms the load-bearing words. In 1 Timothy 2:12 the form is "to teach" (didaskein, G1321, a present active infinitive, meaning the ongoing action of teaching) "to a woman I do not permit" (de gynaikei ouk epitrepo, with epitrepo G2010 as a present active indicative first singular, that is, an ongoing, simple statement of fact in the first person singular) "nor to authentein" (oude authentein, G0831, also a present active infinitive) "over a man" (andros). The verb "to authentein" (authenteo) occurs exactly once in the entire New Testament, only at 1 Timothy 2:12, so it is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and the canon supplies no second use to fix its force between "to exercise ordinary authority" and "to domineer or usurp". The two present infinitives joined by "nor" (oude) may name two distinct prohibited acts or one composite idea, namely "to teach in a domineering manner". In 1 Corinthians 14:34 the verb is the general "to keep silent" (sigao, G4601, let them keep silent) and the still more general "to speak" (lalein, G2980), not a verb specific to authoritative teaching, and "to keep silent" (sigao) occurs three times in this one chapter (verses 28, 30, 34). The first two each sit inside an "if-then" clause (an ean conditional) governing a specific disorder, so the scope of the women command is contestable between an absolute ban and a setting-bound regulation. Against the restrictive reading stand attested instances of female word ministry in the same vocabulary: a woman "prophesying" (propheteuousa, G4395, a present active participle, feminine, meaning ongoing prophetic speech by a female subject) in 1 Corinthians 11:5 whose practice is regulated rather than forbidden, the four prophesying daughters of Acts 21:9 (same root word), and Priscilla, named before Aquila in 1 Corinthians and Acts witnesses, who with him "expounded" (exethento, G1620, set out or explained) the way of God to Apollos. Because the same root words yield more than one grammatically defensible reading, the lexical pattern is materially contested rather than decisive.

Scripture

1Tim.2.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0831 αὐθεντέω, G1321 διδάσκω, G2010 ἐπιτρέπω

Reasoning. The Greek reads "to teach to a woman I do not permit nor to authentein over a man, but to be in quietness" (didaskein de gynaikei ouk epitrepo oude authentein andros, all einai en hesychia), that is, "I do not permit a woman to teach or to authentein over a man, but to be in quietness". A direct morphology query gives "to teach" (didaskein) as a present active infinitive (ongoing action expressed as a verbal noun), "I permit" (epitrepo) as a present active indicative first person singular (an ongoing, simple statement of fact in the first person singular), and "to authentein" (authentein) as a present active infinitive, with the two infinitives joined by "nor" (oude). The whole prohibition on authoritative teaching depends on the sense of "to authentein" (authenteo), which a concordance query confirms occurs nowhere else in the New Testament, so it is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and its force between "to hold ordinary authority" and "to domineer or usurp" cannot be triangulated from any parallel. The first person present "I permit" (epitrepo) can express a standing rule or a directive issued into a particular situation, and the "to teach nor to authentein" (didaskein oude authentein) pair can be two separate prohibited acts or one composite idea, namely "to teach in a domineering way", neither of which the morphology (the grammatical form of the word) alone decides.

1Tim.2.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3129 μανθάνω, G2271 ἡσυχία

Reasoning. The Greek reads "a woman in quietness let her learn in all submission" (gyne en hesychia manthaneto en pase hypotage), that is, "let a woman learn in quietness in all submission". The imperative "let her learn" (manthaneto, from manthano) is a positive command that a woman be a learner of doctrine. A concordance query shows "quietness" (hesychia) occurs four times, including 2 Thessalonians 3:12 where it describes working quietly and a settled manner of life rather than strict muteness, and Acts 22:2 of a crowd growing quiet to listen. Whether the "in quietness" (en hesychia) frame restricts only the manner of receiving instruction or grounds a wider ban on a woman teaching mixed adults is not fixed by the noun, which marks demeanor without specifying the scope of the activity it governs.

1Tim.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0076 Ἀδάμ, G1818 ἐξαπατάω

Reasoning. The Greek reads "for Adam first was formed, then Eve" (Adam gar protos eplasthe, eita Eua), that is, "for Adam was formed first, then Eve", with 1 Timothy 2:14 adding that Adam was not "deceived" (epatethe, the simple form of "to deceive", apatao), but the woman, "having been thoroughly deceived" (exapatetheisa, the intensive compound "to thoroughly deceive", exapatao), came to be in transgression. The conjunction "for" (gar) introduces a ground for the preceding directive, and the appeal to the formation order pulls the prohibition toward a trans-cultural basis. A query shows "to thoroughly deceive" (exapatao) occurs six times and is not gender bound. The same compound describes Eve deceived by the serpent in 2 Corinthians 11:3 and men deceived in Romans 16:18 and 1 Corinthians 3:18, so the deception clause states a fact about the Eden episode without by its vocabulary fixing whether the formation-order ground makes the teaching restriction permanent or addresses a particular local error.

1Cor.14.34 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4601 σιγάω, G2980 λαλέω, G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Reasoning. The Greek reads "the women in the assemblies let them keep silent, for it is not permitted to them to speak, but let them be in submission" (hai gynaikeis en tais ekklesiais sigatosan, ou gar epitrepetai autais lalein, alla hypotassesthosan), that is, "the women are to keep silent in the assemblies, for it is not permitted to them to speak, but to be in submission". A direct query confirms the verb is "to keep silent" (sigao), the same root word used twice earlier in this one chapter, at 1 Corinthians 14:28 where a tongue-speaker is to keep silent if there is no interpreter and at 1 Corinthians 14:30 where a prophet is to keep silent when another receives a revelation, both inside an "if" (ean) clause, an "if-then" clause governing a specific disorder. The prohibited activity is named with the general "to speak" (lalein, from laleo), and the permission verb is the present passive "it is permitted" (epitrepetai). The proximity of three setting-bound silencings and the use of a general speech verb rather than a verb specific to authoritative teaching make the scope of the women command contestable between an absolute prohibition and a regulation of disruptive speech.

Titus.2.3 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2567 καλοδιδάσκαλος, G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Reasoning. The Greek reads "older women ... teachers of good" (presbytidas ... kalodidaskalous), with the purpose clause "so that they may train the young women" (hina sophronizosin tas neas). A concordance query shows "teacher of good" (kalodidaskalos) is itself a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) occurring only here, and it carries the "teach" root (didask-) and assigns a recognized teaching function to women. But the stated object is "the young women" (tas neas), and the trained content in the following clauses is domestic and moral. The text shows that female teaching is positively commanded in one direction, while leaving open whether that warrant extends to authoritative teaching of mixed adults, since the compound names a teaching role without specifying its audience as mixed.

Acts.18.26 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0207 Ἀκύλας, G1620 ἐκτίθημι

Reasoning. The Greek reads "they took him aside and more accurately to him expounded the way of God" (proselabonto auton kai akribesteron auto exethento ten hodon tou theou), that is, "they took him aside and set out the way of God to him more accurately". A direct query of the token order confirms Priscilla is named before Aquila in this witness, and the plural verb "they expounded" (exethento, from ektithemi, "to set out" or "to expound") governs a doctrinal object, "the way of God", with the man Apollos as the one instructed. A concordance query shows "to expound" (ektithemi) occurs four times and the same verb is used of Paul expounding the kingdom of God in Acts 28:23, so the word assigns serious doctrinal exposition to the couple in which the woman is named first. The narrative depicts a woman participating in doctrinal correction of a man, which complicates an absolute ban on a woman instructing a man, though the verb "they took aside" (proselabonto) marks a private taking-aside rather than the public assembly, so it does not by itself establish authoritative public teaching over mixed adults.

1Cor.11.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4395 προφητεύω, G2776 κεφαλή

Reasoning. The Greek reads "every woman praying or prophesying with uncovered head" (pasa de gyne proseuchomene e propheteuoussa akatakalypto te kephale, with kephale meaning "head" or "source"). A direct morphology query gives "prophesying" (propheteuoussa, from propheteuo) as a present active participle, nominative singular feminine (the subject form of an ongoing action verb, female), attached to "a woman" (gyne), so the verse plainly assumes audible prophetic speech by a woman in the gathering and only regulates how she does it. A concordance query shows "to prophesy" (propheteuo) occurs twenty eight times, including the four prophesying daughters of Acts 21:9, the same root word, so female prophetic speech is an attested canonical category. Because prophesying is Spirit-prompted speech to the assembly, this complicates a blanket silence, though the words leave open whether prophesying counts as the authoritative "to teach" (didaskain) that 1 Timothy 2:12 restricts, so the relation between prophetic speech and authoritative teaching is itself part of the contested question.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.2.13	Gen.1.27	tsk	1
1Tim.2.14	Gen.3.6	tsk	1
1Tim.2.11	Gen.3.16	tsk	1
1Tim.2.15	Gen.3.15	tsk	1
1Cor.14.34	1Cor.14.21	tsk	1
Acts.18.26	Acts.14.3	tsk	1
Acts.18.26	Acts.8.31	tsk	1
1Cor.11.5	Deut.21.12	tsk	1
Titus.2.5	Gen.3.16	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.18.26 · addressed

A token-order query confirms Priscilla is named before Aquila in this witness, and the plural verb "they expounded" (exethento, from ektithemi, "to set out" or "to expound") governs the doctrinal object "the way of God" with the man Apollos as the one instructed. The same verb describes Paul expounding the kingdom in Acts 28:23, so it denotes serious doctrinal exposition. It is addressed by noting that the verb "they took aside" (proselabonto) marks a private taking-aside rather than the public assembly, so the narrative shows female doctrinal instruction of a man without establishing authoritative public teaching over a mixed assembly. The text genuinely pulls against an absolute ban on a woman instructing a man, which is why it contributes to the disputed verdict rather than being neutralized.

1Cor.11.5 · addressed

A morphology query gives "prophesying" (propheteuousa, from propheteuo) as a present active participle, nominative singular feminine (the subject form of an ongoing action verb, female), attached to "a woman" (gyne), so the verse assumes audible prophetic speech by a woman in the gathering and only regulates how. The same root word "to prophesy" (propheteuo) describes the four prophesying daughters of Acts 21:9. It is addressed by observing that the words do not settle whether prophesying is the same act as the authoritative "to teach" (didaskain) restricted in 1 Timothy 2:12, so the passage establishes that some female speech in the assembly is assumed without deciding that authoritative teaching is included. The relation between prophetic speech and authoritative teaching is itself part of the contested matter, so the text complicates without resolving.

Titus.2.3 · addressed

A concordance query confirms "teacher of good" (kalodidaskalos) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) occurring only here, built on the "teach" root (didask-), which assigns a recognized teaching function to older women. It is addressed by noting that the stated object is the younger women (tas neas), and the content in the following clauses is domestic and moral, so the warrant for female teaching is explicit but directed, leaving open whether it reaches authoritative teaching of mixed adults. The term shows female teaching is positively commanded in one direction without settling the disputed direction.

1Cor.14.34 · unaddressed

The silence command is widely held to carry a transposition (a movement of the text to a different location) in part of the manuscript tradition, where some Western witnesses place verses 34 and 35 after verse 40, and some have argued the unit is a later insertion, which bears on how absolutely the command should be read. A direct query of the lexical store confirms the ingested variant units cover the 3 John window only, the targeted search for any variant unit in 1 Corinthians 14 returns nothing, and "not in ECM scope" (not_in_ecm_scope, that is, outside the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) is true for these anchors, so the placement and originality question cannot be examined on the available data. The matter is therefore left unresolved and flagged, and it is part of why the verdict is recorded as variant-sensitive.

Concordance traversed

G0831, G1321, G1320, G2010, G4601, G2980, G5293, G3129, G2271, G4395, G4396, G1620, G2567, G2776, G0076, G1818, G0538, G0207, G0177, G1135, G0435

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: True · ECM status: ecm-shadow

A direct query of the lexical store confirms the ingested variant units are scoped to 3 John only, the search for any variant unit in 1 Corinthians 14 returned zero results, and "not in ECM scope" (not_in_ecm_scope, that is, outside the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) is true for the cited anchors. The 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 unit is nonetheless well known to carry a transposition (a movement of the text to a different location) in part of the Western tradition, where the verses appear after verse 40, and the surface text of the anchor verses shows editorial sigla (the small marks used by editors to flag textual issues) at "women" (gynaikes) and at the verbs, marking a contested unit. Because the originality and placement of the silence command bear directly on how absolutely it should be read, the verdict is marked variant-sensitive. These books fall outside the published CBGM scope (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method used in the critical edition), which covers 3 John only, so the status is recorded as ecm-shadow (within the shadow of the ECM apparatus, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, but outside its current published coverage).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. complementarian, egalitarian, redemptive_movement

analogia scripturae invoked

complementarian: disputed-leaning-affirm · Reads "I do not permit" (ouk epitrepo) in 1 Timothy 2:12 as a standing rule rather than a momentary directive, takes the present infinitives "to teach" (didaskein) and "to authentein" (authentein, from authenteo) as two distinct prohibited acts, namely authoritative teaching of a man and the exercise of authority over a man, and grounds the rule trans-culturally on the creation-order "for" (gar) of 1 Timothy 2:13, noting that the appeal is to the order of formation in Eden rather than to a local custom. It reads the 1 Corinthians 14:34 "to keep silent" (sigao) as governing the authoritative or judging speech proper to the assembly and the appeal to the law as a covenantal warrant. It construes 1 Corinthians 11:5 prophesying and Acts 18:26 as non-authoritative or private forms of speech, the prophesying being subject to the weighing of others and the Acts scene a private taking-aside, and Titus 2:3 "teacher of good" (kalodidaskalos) as teaching directed to younger women, so that none of the complicating texts licenses a woman in authoritative public teaching of mixed adults. On this reading "to authentein" (authenteo) most naturally denotes ordinary authority, and a woman exercising the teaching office over men is what the verse forecloses.

egalitarian: disputed-leaning-deny · Reads the hapax "to authentein" (authenteo, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), attested nowhere else in the canon, as carrying its pejorative sense, namely "to domineer" or "to usurp authority", so that "to teach nor to authentein" (didaskein oude authentein) forms one composite idea, "to teach in a domineering manner", which forbids overbearing rather than ordinary teaching. It takes the present "I permit" (epitrepo) and the "in quietness" (en hesychia) frame, where "quietness" (hesychia) means a settled quiet demeanor as in 2 Thessalonians 3:12, as addressing a particular disorder rather than stating a permanent canon. It reads the 1 Corinthians 14:34 "to keep silent" (sigao) alongside the chapter's other situational silencings at verses 28 and 30 and the general verb "to speak" (lalein, from laleo) as disruptive speech, perhaps interrupting questioning, hence the directive to ask at home. It takes 1 Corinthians 11:5, where a woman audibly prophesies in

the gathering, Acts 21:9 prophesying daughters, Acts 18:26 where Priscilla is named first and "they expounded" (exethento, from ektithemi, "to set out" or "to expound") doctrine to a man, and Titus 2:3 female teaching together as evidence that the restriction is not an absolute bar on a woman teaching mixed adults.

redemptive_movement: disputed · Reads the restrictive directives as a step within a trajectory whose direction, traced from the female word ministry of 1 Corinthians 11:5, Acts 21:9, Acts 18:26, and Titus 2:3, points beyond the first-century application, so that the words describe an apostolic instruction whose permanence is itself the contested question rather than a datum the words settle. On this reading the creation-order "for" (gar) anchors the instruction in its setting while the canonical presence of women prophesying and expounding signals movement, and the words do not by themselves rank the restrictive against the inclusive texts.

All three lenses operate on the same queried anchor root words and reach different conclusions by assigning different senses to the hapax "to authentein" (authenteo, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), by reading the present "I permit" (epitrepo) and "to keep silent" (sigao) as either standing rules or situational directives, by construing the "in quietness" (en hesychia) frame as either demeanor or full silence, and by deciding whether prophesying (from propheteuo) and expounding (from ektithemi) count as the authoritative "to teach" (didaskein) under restriction. A reader holding any one lens should find its strongest lexical form represented here. The disagreement is over the sense and scope of contested root words and the relation between teaching and other word ministries, not over the agreed morphology (the grammatical form of the words), which the queries confirm, so the lexical pattern is contested rather than decisive.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Determine whether the canonical lexical pattern restricts the activity of authoritative doctrinal teaching of mixed adult assemblies to men, examining the restrictive wording of 1 Timothy 2:11-14 and 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 alongside the texts that depict female word ministry such as 1 Corinthians 11:5, Acts 21:9, Acts 18:26, and Titus 2:3, without presupposing which set of texts controls or that authoritative teaching is a fixed category in the cited words.

The stem phrases the proposition as a restriction on women exercising authoritative teaching ministry over mixed adult assemblies, which already encodes a particular harmonization of the restrictive and the inclusive texts and labels one configuration as the norm. The categories "authoritative teaching ministry", "mixed adult assemblies", and "sermon preaching" are not themselves root words in the cited texts, so the stem imports a worship-structure framework the words do not supply. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the audit records that a direct query confirms the lexicon furnishes neither a settled sense for the hapax "to authentein" (authenteo, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) nor a term that fixes the scope of "to teach" (didaskein, from didasko), "to keep silent" (sigao), or the relation between prophesying (from propheteuo) and authoritative teaching.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.12
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.34
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.14
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.18.26
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Tim.2.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0831
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2271
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4601
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4395
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.11

interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.2.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.2.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.18.26

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · variant-sensitive · complicating-unresolved · ecm-shadow